



buffalo so that there's enough milk for my children. My wife also makes sure that almonds are ground so that Priya gets the right nutrition. All this costs money, but *mere mein bhi junoon hai* (Even I have my passion). Right now, our priority is to make sure that Priya doesn't lack anything," he says.

Within a year of joining the Bhiwani Boxing Academy, Priya's luck began to change. She won the district and then State youth title in 2023 and followed that up with the national title. After repeating the same wins the next year, she competed at the Asian Youth Championships, where she won silver. Her career trajectory has only risen since then.

Incidentally, her record has mirrored that of Neeraj, who had also won a national youth title and a silver medal at the Asian Youth Championships. This often leads to some good-natured teasing between the two.

"They'll compare each other's results. One of them will say, 'I've won this medal, when are you going to win this?'" says Mahendra.

But Priya has actual role models.

"I really like (Kazakh men's world champion in the 70kg category) Torekhan Sabyrkhan. When he boxes, he is in complete control of his skills. He's actually my age, and I've run into him at two tournaments, but both times I've been too shy to say anything to him. But he's so confident when he boxes," she says.

This year, though, Priya has started making strides of her own. She competed at her first senior national championships in Noida, where she took silver behind World Champion Jaismine Lamboriya. She might have fallen short of the title there, but she more than made up for it at the Asian Championships.

Over the course of the tournament, those around her saw her confidence grow. Although she had a tough opponent in the final, Un-gyong, who had beaten Olympic champion Lin Yu Ting in the semifinal, Priya had been brimming with self-belief.

For her part, Priya remained upbeat. "I spoke to her before the final, and she was very confident. She said *koi dikkat nahi hai* (there's

Carving a niche: From a modest boxing academy in Haryana to the top of the Asian podium, Priya Ghanghas' rise is built on grit, talent, and the unwavering faith of her coach.

no problem)," says Mahavir.

While a gold on international debut is no small achievement, Mahavir says her best is yet to come.

"You look out for her after that also. She is a special talent," he says.

Priya, too, has started setting bigger goals for herself.

"The best part of winning the Asian Championships title was that I got to stand on the podium and listen to the national anthem. I want to do that at the Asian Games and at the Olympics as well," she says.

More than anything, though, she wants to see herself as she did in the video she keeps returning to on her phone. "The best boxers in the world carry this confidence even before they enter the ring. When I see that video of myself, I feel I had that same kind of confidence and belief. I want to always be able to box like that," she says.